China is immense: India earmarked $150 million in AI, compared with a Chinese effort to generate $150 billion, and Indian start-ups have been able to raise $87 million, in contrast with an estimated $28 billion raised by Chinese start-ups in 2017.'[29] For an Indian military planner, the sheer magnitude of China's investments must be sobering.

One final view on how the two militaries compare. During the peak of the Ladakh crisis in 2020, some Indian commentators argued that the combat effectiveness of Chinese ground forces is questionable. China's one-child policy means that many recruits – perhaps most – are the only child of their parents. The nervousness of Chinese parents over the safety of their sons would apparently communicate to the young men serving in Ladakh who would be hesitant to fight. Again, the fact that China has not fought a war since 1979 would add to the fragility of Chinese units in actual combat. Indian troops, by contrast, are presumably expendable because their families have more than one child. They are able therefore to fight without worry. Also, the Indian military has recent war experience to draw on. It fought in Kargil in 1999 and has been on almost continuous counter-insurgency duty since the early 1980s.

This rather reassuring argument deserves a thought or two. First, judging by the fight at Galwan, it would be hard to conclude that the Chinese fought any less effectively than the Indian troops. In any case, this perspective fundamentally misunderstands why troops fight: they fight for the safety and regard of 'buddies' and officers in their small units and perhaps for the honour of their communities or families at home. They fight for survival and self-respect, in those desperate moments, and it is very doubtful that parental concerns over their safety hold them back. Second, given that the ordinary Indian soldier on average has roughly fifteen years of active service in a combat role, very few have any war experience behind them – those who fought in Kargil twenty years ago are no longer front-line troops, if indeed they are still with the army. Third, counter-insurgency is very different from war, where Indian troops will fight a professional army backed by the full panoply of modern arms and logistics. The experience in one form of combat does not necessarily transfer to the other. Fourth, the